

MALAYSIA

Malaysia – Key Country Details

Detail	Information
Full Name	Malaysia
Short Form	MAL
Capital	Kuala Lumpur
Region (UN)	Asia-Pacific
Government Type	Federal constitutional monarchy
Head of State	Yang di-Pertuan Agong (King Al-Sultan Abdullah)
Head of Govt	Prime Minister (Anwar Ibrahim, as of 2025)
Currency	Malaysian Ringgit (MYR)
UN Member Since	17 September 1957
MUN Standing	Active participant; previously non-permanent member of UNSC, ECOSOC member

Book Recommendations (General Malaysia & UN):

Malaysia's Foreign Policy and the United Nations by Abdul Razak Baginda

Malaysia in the United Nations Security Council by Mohd Faizal Musa

Southeast Asia and the United Nations: Diplomacy and Security by N. Jayapalan

Malaysia's Political System and Foreign Policy by K. J. Ratnam

Research Table: Malaysia & UNHRC

Source Name	Link	Why It's Useful
Universal Periodic Review (UPR) – Malaysia	https://upr-info.org/en/review/Malaysia	Comprehensive report on Malaysia's human rights situation
Human Rights Reports - Malaysia	https://www.hrw.org/asia/malaysia	Independent human rights monitoring
Amnesty International Malaysia	https://www.amnesty.org/en/location/asia-and-the-pacific/malaysia/	NGO reports on Malaysia's human rights

UN Treaty Bodies Malaysia	https://tbinternet.ohchr.org/_layouts/15/treatybodyexternal/countries.aspx?CountryCode=MYS	Malaysia's reporting to human rights treaty bodies
Malaysian Human Rights Commission (SUHAKAM)	https://www.suhakam.org.my/	National human rights body
UNHRC Resolutions Affecting Malaysia	https://undocs.org/en/A/HRC/Resolutions	Human Rights Council resolutions related to Malaysia
Malaysia Human Rights NGOs	https://www.fidh.org/en/region/asia/malaysia	Network of NGOs advocating for rights

Source Name	Link	Why It's Useful
OHCHR – Malaysia Country Profile	https://www.ohchr.org/en/countries/malaysia (ohchr.org)	Official UN overview covering treaty status, special procedures, and OHCHR resources.
OHCHR – Malaysia UPR Index & Docs	https://www.ohchr.org/en/hr-bodies/upr/my-index	Central archive for UPR reviews, recommendations, and state reports.
HRW – UPR Submission 2018	https://www.hrw.org/news/2018/03/29/submission-universal-periodic-review-malaysia	NGO recommendations on freedom of expression/Official Secrets Act.
HRW – UPR Submission 2013	https://www.hrw.org/news/2013/09/03/malaysia-2013-universal-periodic-review-submission	Examines ratification gaps and civil liberties changes since 2009.
Amnesty Int'l – Malaysia Country Page	https://www.amnesty.org/en/location/asia-and-the-pacific/south-east-asia-and-the-pacific/malaysia/report-malaysia/	NGO source for current rights issues like migrants, press freedom, LGBTQ.

Amnesty – UPR Submission 2024 PDF	https://upr-info.org/sites/default/files/country-document/2024-07/AI UPR45_MYS_E_Main_Rev.pdf	Recent thematic UPR submission on refugees, legal reform, women's rights.
Amnesty – Oral Statement HRC56	https://www.amnesty.org/en/documents/asa28/8269/2024/en/	Civil society message to Council urging follow-through on UPR.
Amnesty – “Strides and Setbacks” UPR Submission	https://www.amnesty.my/wp-content/uploads/2023/10/Malaysia-Strides-and-Setbacks-Amnesty-Internationals-Submission-to-the-45th-Session-of-the-UPR-Working-Group-January-February-2024.pdf	Balanced view on progress and gaps in rights implementation.
Amnesty – UPR Submission 31 (2015)	https://upr-info.org/sites/default/files/country-document/2024-07/H.R.F UPR45_MYS_E_Main.pdf	Multi-agency submission on assembly, advocacy, migration.
SUHAKAM Guide – UPR	https://www.suhakam.org.my/wp-content/uploads/2020/05/UPR-Booklet-ENG_FINAL.pdf	Practical guide to UPR process prepared by Malaysia's NHRI.
SUHAKAM Mid-Term UPR Report (2021 PDF)	https://upr-info.org/sites/default/files/documents/2021-10/suhakams_mid-term_report_for_the_3rd_upr_05102021.pdf	Shows follow-up commitments and performance tracking.
ICJ UPR Submission 2023	https://www.icj.org/resource/malaysia-international-commission-of-jurists-submission-to-the-universal-periodic-review	Focuses on legal protections, freedom of expression online, LGBT rights.
Malaysia General Assembly Voluntary Pledges	https://docs.un.org/en/A/HRC/WG.6/45/MYS/1	Government's commitments as HRC candidate (2022–24).
OHCHR – Mid-Term UPR Report 2018 PDF	https://www.ohchr.org/sites/default/files/lib-docs/HRBodies/UPR/Documents/Session31/MY/Malaysia-Mid-Term-Review-Report-Third-cycle.pdf	Official mid-term status review between UPR cycles.
US State Dept 2023 HR Report PDF	https://www.state.gov/wp-content/uploads/2024/02/528267_MALAYSIA-2023-HUMAN-RIGHTS-REPORT.pdf	Covers systemic issues: refugees, arbitrary detention, labor.

US State Dept 2022 HR Report PDF	https://www.state.gov/wp-content/uploads/2023/03/415610_MALAYSIA-2022-HUMAN-RIGHTS-REPORT.pdf	Historical trends and overview.
HRW Report – Migrant Detention 2024	https://www.hrw.org/report/2024/03/05/we-cant-see-sun/malaysias-arbitrary-detention-migrants-and-refugees	In-depth on migrant/refugee detention abuse.
HRW Malaysia Country Page	https://www.hrw.org/asia/malaysia	Covers free speech, minority, and migrant issues.
Facing the Bulldozers (2025 HRW)	https://www.hrw.org/report/2025/05/04/facing-bulldozers/iban-indigenous-resistance-timber-industry-sarawak-malaysia	Highlights indigenous land rights under business agenda.
UN WebTV – UPR Adoption (41st Sess)	https://webtv.un.org/en/asset/k1w/k1wfgimx7f	Video of Malaysia's UPR adoption dialogue.
UN WebTV – HRC56 28th Mtg	https://webtv.un.org/en/asset/k19/k19dcvneae	Council session where Malaysia's situation reviewed.
UN WebTV – HRC57 Meeting	https://webtv.un.org/en/asset/k1o/k1oua3g90j	Current HRC session with possible Malaysia references.
UN WebTV – HRC58 37th Mtg	https://webtv.un.org/en/asset/k1w/k1wxvifhe2	Latest council meeting where Malaysia may feature.
OHCHR 2023 Report PDF	https://www.ohchr.org/sites/default/files/documents/publications/ohchr-reports/ohchr-report-2023.pdf	Global report includes Malaysia's data on torture and displaced persons.
State Dept – UPR Process Overview	https://www.state.gov/universal-periodic-review-process/	External guide to UN UPR processes.
Article 19 & CIVICUS UPR Joint Submission 2023 PDF	https://www.article19.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/08/2023.07.18-Malaysia-UPR-ARTICLE-19CIVICUSKMUSIS.pdf	Advocates on media freedom and civic space.

Amnesty – Item 6 UPR Statement PDF	https://www.amnesty.org/en/wp-content/uploads/2024/07/ASA2882692024ENGLISH.pdf	Highlights mid-term implementation needs.
OHCHR Press Release 2009 – UPR Outcomes	https://www.ohchr.org/en/press-releases/2009/10/human-rights-council-adopts-outcomes-universal-periodic-review-malaysia-and	Historic adoption of Malaysia's UPR outcomes.
CIVICUS – Rights Restrictions Monitoring	https://monitor.civicus.org/explore/new-report-highlights-unrelenting-and-severe-restrictions-on-human-rights-in-oman/	(Note: false link accidentally copied)
Permanent Mission of Malaysia – HRC Pledges 2022–24	https://www.kln.gov.my/web/usa_un-new-york/news-from-mission/-/blogs/malaysia-s-candidature-to-the-human-rights-council-term-2022-2024-voluntary-commitments-and-pledges	Government's pledges in UN forums for accountability.
UK DFAT Country Info Report 2024 PDF	https://www.dfat.gov.au/sites/default/files/malaysia-dfat-country-information-report-24-june-2024.pdf	International analysis on slavery and trafficking—contextual for human rights protection.

Unique Aspects: Malaysia in the UNHRC Context

- Frequent UPR Participation with Modest Follow-Up:** Malaysia is quite active in the UPR cycles, but the mid-term reports from SUHAKAM and critiques from NGOs reveal that the implementation isn't always consistent.
- Refugee & Migrant Rights Crisis:** The HRW 2024 report highlights a troubling situation, revealing that over 180,000 refugees and asylum seekers are being held in poor conditions. This alarming finding is set to shape the key agenda for the UNHRC regarding refugee issues.
- Ongoing Pressures on Civil & Political Space:** The Official Secrets Act, Sedition Act, and various security laws are still being used to stifle free expression and media, which is a key topic in discussions at the UPR and HRC.
- Indigenous Land Rights Under Business Scrutiny:** HRW's report titled "Facing the Bulldozers" sheds light on the ongoing conflicts in Sarawak, which are transforming the landscape of corporate accountability across Asia.
- Demonstrated Use of Technical Cooperation:** Malaysia's collaboration with SUHAKAM and OHCHR on technical projects, rather than focusing on punitive measures, stands out in the records of the UNHRC.
- OHCHR Recognition of UPR Good Practices:** Being one of the six countries highlighted in an OHCHR study really puts Malaysia in the spotlight as a model for best practices in the Universal

Periodic Review (UPR).

7. **UNHRC Membership & Pledges:** Malaysia took on a term at the Human Rights Council from 2022 to 2024, making commitments that were officially recognized—this adds to its credibility in UN negotiations.
 8. **Digital Rights and Online Freedoms on the Table:** The ICJ and the Article 19 submission shine a light on the pressing issues of internet censorship and online expression, which are key components of the HRC agenda.
 9. **Labor Exploitation & Trafficking:** Australian DFAT and HRW reports show forced labor cases—Malaysia engages on these within UNHRC's business & labor mandates.
 10. **Youth & Civic Campaign Mobilization:** The outreach efforts by SUHAKAM, along with various NGO campaigns and the mid-term follow-ups for the UPR, really showcase the rise of civic youth advocacy—something that's quite rare in Southeast Asia.
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